

Risk Matrix Template

Assess likelihood and impact to prioritise your testing effort.

Introduction

A risk matrix helps you turn risk-based testing from a slogan into a plan. By scoring each risk on likelihood and impact, you decide where to test first and hardest. This template gives you a reusable structure.

The Core Formula

Risk level = likelihood × impact. Likelihood is the probability the problem occurs; impact is the harm if it does. Multiplying the two gives a comparable score across risks.

Scoring Scale

Score	Likelihood	Impact
1 — Low	Unlikely to occur	Minor inconvenience, easy workaround
2 — Medium	Could reasonably occur	Noticeable disruption to users or business
3 — High	Very likely to occur	Severe or business-critical harm

Risk Level Matrix

Likelihood \ Impact	Low (1)	Medium (2)	High (3)
High (3)	3 — Medium	6 — High	9 — Critical
Medium (2)	2 — Low	4 — Medium	6 — High
Low (1)	1 — Low	2 — Low	3 — Medium

Priority Bands

Score	Band	Testing response
7–9	Critical	Test earliest, most thoroughly; consider extra techniques
4–6	High	Test carefully within the plan
2–3	Medium	Standard coverage
1	Low	Light or exploratory coverage only

Worked Example

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Score	Priority
Payment fails to process	2	3	6	High
Login rejects valid users	2	3	6	High
Cosmetic misalignment on footer	3	1	3	Medium
Report export corrupts data	1	3	3	Medium

Blank Reusable Template

Risk	Type (product/project)	Likelihood (1-3)	Impact (1-3)	Score	Owner	Mitigation

Instructions

1. List each identified risk, one per row.
2. Classify it as a product risk or a project risk.
3. Score likelihood and impact from 1 to 3.
4. Multiply to get the risk level and assign a priority band.
5. Record an owner and a mitigation or test response.
6. Re-review scores as the project progresses.

Best Practices

- Involve both business and technical stakeholders in scoring.
- Revisit the matrix at each milestone — risks change.
- Use it to justify where testing effort goes.

Common Mistakes

- Scoring impact alone and ignoring likelihood (or vice versa).
- Treating the matrix as fixed for the whole project.
- Confusing high severity with high risk — severity is only part of impact.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Keep the matrix visible to the whole team. When a stakeholder asks why a low-value feature was not tested exhaustively, the risk matrix is your evidence-based answer.